WEEK 9 · LECTURE L3 · UNITS III AND IV

Sponsorship and Equity

The functions of mentoring, a social capital theory of careers, the paradox of meritocracy, and fair advancement.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Distinguish Kram's career and psychosocial functions of mentoring.
- Explain sponsorship using social capital theory.
- Evaluate the evidence on the paradox of meritocracy.
- Design a fairer system for advancement and talent review.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 5 (create talent development programs) and CLO 2 (apply engagement strategies).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Two engineers are both rated 4.5. One gets a stretch assignment after a senior leader speaks for her. Is that merit?

Yes, no, or merit plus something else. If something else, name it.

THE ORIGINAL THEORY · KRAM (1985)

The two functions of mentoring

Career functions	Psychosocial functions
Sponsorship	Role modeling
Exposure and visibility	Acceptance and confirmation
Coaching	Counseling
Protection and challenging assignments	Friendship

EXAM LENS

Sponsorship was always part of mentoring. The modern debate is about which function people actually receive.

DOES MENTORING WORK?

Small effects, and an unequal ingredient

EBY ET AL. (2008)

Mentoring relates to better behavioral, attitudinal, health, motivational and career outcomes, but most effects are small.

IBARRA, CARTER AND SILVA (2010)

Women received mentoring, but less of the sponsorship that leads to promotion.

THEORY IN DEPTH · SEIBERT, KRAIMER AND LIDEN (2001)

A social capital theory of career success

THE CORE IDEA

Network structure gives access to information, resources and career sponsorship, which lead to career success.

HOW IT WORKS

Weak ties bring new information (Granovetter, 1973); bridging unconnected groups brings advantage (Burt, 1992).

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Networks partly reflect existing advantage, so cause and effect are entangled.

IN PRACTICE

A sponsor spends their own social capital on a protege. That is why sponsorship is scarce and unequally spread.

EXAM LENS

Use it to explain why sponsorship matters more than advice for promotion.

THEORY IN DEPTH · CASTILLA (2008); CASTILLA AND BENARD (2010)

The paradox of meritocracy

THE CORE IDEA

Equal performance ratings did not guarantee equal rewards, and meritocratic framing could increase bias.

HOW IT WORKS

In experiments with 445 managers, a culture presented as meritocratic led to more favoring of men over equally performing women.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Experiments and single firm studies; the paradox may vary across cultures.

IN PRACTICE

Castilla (2015): in one firm, adding accountability and transparency to pay decisions reduced pay gaps.

EXAM LENS

Use it to argue that merit systems need accountability and transparency, not just the label of merit.

WHERE BIAS ENTERS A TALENT REVIEW

Judging potential, and the broken rung

SILZER AND CHURCH (2009)

Potential is harder to observe than performance, so judgments of it are more open to bias.

MCKINSEY AND LEANIN.ORG (2019)

For every 100 men promoted and hired to manager, only 72 women were.

LEVENTHAL (1980)

Consistency, accuracy, correctability and representation are tests a talent review can fail.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Mentoring versus sponsorship

	Mentoring	Sponsorship
Main function	Advice and support	Advocacy and visibility
Cost to the senior	Time	Their own reputation
Effect on promotion	Indirect	Direct
Equity risk	Low	High, unless allocated fairly

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Mentoring programs fail women because they offer advice, not advocacy." Critically evaluate. **20 marks**

A strong answer: uses Kram, Eby et al. and Ibarra et al.; explains sponsorship through social capital; proposes a fair sponsorship design.

"A meritocratic culture ensures fairness." Discuss using the paradox of meritocracy. **20 marks**

A strong answer: reports Castilla and Benard accurately; adds Castilla (2015); applies Leventhal; designs safeguards for an Indian firm.

Distinguish Kram's career and psychosocial functions. **10 marks**

A strong answer: lists both; one example each; which links more to promotion.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. Sponsorship spends social capital; that is why it is scarce
2. Calling a culture meritocratic can increase bias
3. Accountability and transparency narrowed pay gaps in one firm

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Buckingham, M., & Clifton, D. O. (2001). *Now, discover your strengths*. Free Press. Chapter 1.

Cappelli, P. (2008). *Talent on demand: Managing talent in an age of uncertainty*. Harvard Business Press. Chapter on internal mobility.

Hewlett, S. A. (2013). *Forget a mentor, find a sponsor: The new way to fast track your career*. Harvard Business Review Press. Chapter 1.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 9 set readings. Hewlett (2013) is the core reading for this lecture.

Sources for this lecture (1 of 3)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Burt, R. S. (1992). *Structural holes: The social structure of competition*. Harvard University Press.

Castilla, E. J. (2008). Gender, race, and meritocracy in organizational careers. *American Journal of Sociology, 113*(6), 1479–1526. https://doi.org/10.1086/588738

Castilla, E. J. (2015). Accounting for the gap: A firm study manipulating organizational accountability and transparency in pay decisions. *Organization Science, 26*(2), 311–333. https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.2014.0950

Castilla, E. J., & Benard, S. (2010). The paradox of meritocracy in organizations. *Administrative Science Quarterly, 55*(4), 543–676. https://doi.org/10.2189/asqu.2010.55.4.543

Sources for this lecture (2 of 3)

Eby, L. T., Allen, T. D., Evans, S. C., Ng, T., & DuBois, D. L. (2008). Does mentoring matter? A multidisciplinary meta analysis comparing mentored and non mentored individuals. *Journal of Vocational Behavior, 72*(2), 254–267. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jvb.2007.04.005

Granovetter, M. S. (1973). The strength of weak ties. *American Journal of Sociology, 78*(6), 1360–1380. https://doi.org/10.1086/225469

Ibarra, H., Carter, N. M., & Silva, C. (2010). Why men still get more promotions than women. *Harvard Business Review, 88*(9).

Kram, K. E. (1985). *Mentoring at work: Developmental relationships in organizational life*. Scott, Foresman.

Sources for this lecture (3 of 3)

Leventhal, G. S. (1980). What should be done with equity theory? In K. J. Gergen, M. S. Greenberg, & R. H. Willis (Eds.), *Social exchange: Advances in theory and research* (pp. 27–55). Plenum.

McKinsey & Company, & LeanIn.Org. (2019). *Women in the workplace 2019*. McKinsey & Company.

Seibert, S. E., Kraimer, M. L., & Liden, R. C. (2001). A social capital theory of career success. *Academy of Management Journal, 44*(2), 219–237. https://doi.org/10.2307/3069452

Silzer, R., & Church, A. H. (2009). The pearls and perils of identifying potential. *Industrial and Organizational Psychology, 2*(4), 377–412. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1754-9434.2009.01163.x